



Above On Easter Sunday, lamb marinated in lemon juice, olive oil, and oregano is spit-roasted over coals as the centerpiece of the Easter feast

Left The small, medieval village of Triantaros lies 4 miles (6 km) northeast of Tinos town, and is home to the picturesque Church of the Holy Apostles



Above A Greek Orthodox priest prays over the *epitaphios*, a sacred cloth carrying an image of Christ, taken into the sea at Tinos on Good Friday

What Else to Eat

Lamb is often stewed with **artichokes** here: it's one of the few crops that thrive on the wind-whipped island. Locals battle it out for the best recipe at the Artichoke Festival in the village of Komi in May. Buy marinated artichoke hearts (*aginaires*) and other Tinian delicacies straight from the source at the daily farmers' market by Tinos port: **thyme honey** thick as treacle, slabs of **louza** (cured pork), **graviera** cheese, and necklaces of **sun-dried tomatoes**. Many of these find their way into **fourtalia**, the delicious frittata of the Cyclades. The ultimate comfort food is **fourtalia** with **fennel-seed sausage** at To Agnandi (+30 22830 21095), a quaint *ouzeri*/grocery in Ktikados.

The Best Places to Eat Greek Lamb

Ta Isternia inexpensive

It's extremely hard to have a bad meal on Tinos, but some tavernas are quietly but consistently sensational. This unassuming local haunt is one of them. While two (admittedly excellent) rival restaurants – Thalassaki and Naftilos – battle it out on the waterfront at Isternia bay, those in the know escape the crowds and head up the treacherous, winding road to the village of Isternia proper. Tucked away on a back street near the parking lot, this is the only taverna in town. Despite the lack of competition, its owners Nikos and Anna maintain very high standards. They serve traditional Greek food with a Tinian twist: caper croquettes, garlic and potato dip, black-eyed beans with sun-dried tomatoes. The traditional Easter feast is cooked exactly as it should be: tender lamb that falls off the bone, lemony potatoes that fall apart in your mouth, and crisp lettuce salad. The small terrace has a handful of tables with ravishing views of the Aegean.

Isternia, Tinos; open 1 PM–midnight Easter–Sep; +30 22830 31005

Also on Tinos

Douar (+30 22830 41231; *inexpensive*) in the village of Steni is a *hasapotaverna* (a butcher and no-frills restaurant) that is strictly for carnivores. Gruff service and cramped tables don't deter the regulars, who come from miles away to gnaw on the addictive lamb chops.

Also in Greece

The tradition of roasting whole lambs on a spit comes from **Roumeli**, a region in central Greece. On Easter Sunday, residents in its towns of **Livadia**, **Amfiklia**, and **Amfissa** set up makeshift barbecues on the streets and offer hunks of roast lamb and *kokoretsi* (skewered innards encased in intestines) to all passers-by.

Around the World

George Calombaris is one of Australia's most influential chefs. **The Press Club** (www.thepressclub.com.au; *expensive*), his flashy but accessible flagship restaurant in Melbourne, is an exemplary showcase for modern Greek food. Dramatically presented, deceptively simple dishes include roast loin of lamb with beet *horiatiki* (a salad with feta cheese) and almond *skordalia* (a thick, garlicky purée). Greeks eat leftover lamb sandwiches for days after Easter, and you can recreate the experience in Palo Alto, California, at **Evvia Estiatorio** (www.evvia.net; *moderate*). This upmarket Greek restaurant in Silicon Valley serves roasted-lamb pita-bread sandwiches with tzatziki, tomato, and seasonal greens.